VIII—Talent and Destiny

> ‘The vulgar believe in miracles, but the wise man accepts nothing without adequate proof.’
>
> – Akbar, Happy Sayings, *Ain-i-Akbari*

Gujarat was subdued. There would be bursts of resistance against Mughal rule for years to come, yes. That young prince of Gujarat, Nannu, last seen hiding in a field of wheat, would lead a spirited and tragic fight for his throne. Gulrukh – Ibrahim Mirza’s widow, Kamran’s daughter, a refugee in the Deccan – would raise her son to stake a claim in Akbar’s empire. Never again, however, would the padishah himself have to come hurtling to the western shores of his realm; its revenues would flow into his treasury as surely as the Sabarmati flowed into the Arabian Sea.

There was, in fact, very little hurtling left in Akbar’s future. Conquests, many: Bengal would come next, then much of the north and north-west, including Sindh and Kashmir; in his sixties, Akbar would march down to the Deccan and supervise the siege of one last great fort, Asirgarh. Rarely, however, would the padishah – or rather, as Abul Fazl refers to him, the shahinshah, the king of kings – lead armies into battle any more.

Partly this may be because there were many talented men who would lead his armies for him: that old stalwart Munim Khan, of course, but also Abdur Rahim and his guardian Man Singh, Aziz and the fallen Saif’s brother Zain. Even the two unpopular accountants, Muzaffar Khan and Todar Mal, and our own Abul Fazl, would prove themselves gifted generals. Akbar could leave much of the work of conquering land to these men, and turn his own energies to the less glamorous work of building an empire.

For this, it was not armies that Akbar needed to overcome, but his own nobility – and he did so with a slow-grinding obstinacy that, while not as spectacular as a gallop to Gujarat, was equally stunning in its result: the transformation of a self-willed military aristocracy into a meek, salaried, even worshipful bureaucracy.

But first, he would have to find the man to help him do it.

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The pre-monsoon showers of 1574 brought two young men of exceptional